SOUTH CAROLINA

The Palmetto State



The South Carolina Lowcountry is a landscape that seems to exist between worlds—neither fully land nor fully sea, but a vast, shifting geography of tidal creeks, salt marshes, and barrier islands stretching from Georgetown down through Beaufort and into the sea islands beyond Charleston. It is one of the most ecologically rich places in North America, and for centuries it has fed the people who learned to read it.

Those people, in large part, were the Gullah—descendants of enslaved West and Central Africans who were brought to the Carolina coast beginning in the late 1600s specifically because their knowledge of rice cultivation was unmatched anywhere in the colonial world. The British planters who built their fortunes along the Ashley and Cooper Rivers understood almost nothing about growing rice in tidal conditions. The Africans they enslaved, drawn from the rice-farming cultures of Sierra Leone, Senegal, and the Congo basin, understood everything. They engineered the inland swamps, built the floodgates, and cultivated the crop that would make South Carolina one of the wealthiest colonies in America. The profits went to the planters. The knowledge, and the cooking that grew from it, belonged to the Gullah.

Rice was never just a crop to Gullah people—it was culture, comfort, and ceremony. And from that deep relationship with rice came perloo, a one-pot dish of layered flavors and unhurried patience, most likely descended from the West African jollof rice tradition and shaped over generations by what the Lowcountry abundantly provided. The tidal creeks and estuaries surrounding the sea islands—Daufuskie, St. Helena, Edisto, Hilton Head—teemed with shrimp so plentiful that Gullah families could harvest them by the basketful from the pluff mud flats at low tide. Smoked sausage, deeply seasoned and rich, came from the hog-butchering traditions that were central to Gullah community life, particularly in the cooler months when families gathered and nothing was wasted.

Together, shrimp and sausage met rice in a single heavy pot—absorbing stock, smoke, and seasoning until every grain was swollen with flavor and the whole became something far greater than its parts. Gullah cooks on St. Helena Island and in the streets of Beaufort were making versions of this dish long before it appeared on any restaurant menu or in any Southern cookbook. It fed field workers and fishermen, church suppers and funeral repasts, celebrations and ordinary Tuesday evenings with equal generosity.

When you make this dish, you are stepping into that long tradition—one built not on precision and fuss, but on instinct, patience, and the confidence that a good pot of perloo will always find its people. Let the rice absorb every drop of that smoky, briny broth. Don't rush it. The reward is a spoonful so deeply satisfying, so layered with the flavors of the Carolina coast, that the table will go quiet in the very best way.

GULLAH SHRIMP AND SAUSAGE PERLOO

A soulful, one-pot rice dish rooted in the Gullah Geechee tradition of the South Carolina Lowcountry, where West African culinary heritage simmers together with smoky sausage and sweet Atlantic shrimp.

Yield: 6 servings

INGREDIENTS

SHRIMP & STOCK

- 1 lb. shrimp, peeled and deveined
- 3 cups chicken stock
- 1 bay leaf (optional)

BASE

- 4 oz. smoked sausage, smoked neck bones or salt-cured pork, diced
- 1 medium onion, diced
- 1 bell pepper, diced
- 3 cloves garlic, minced
- 3 Tbsp tomato paste
- 1 can (14.5 oz.) diced tomatoes (with juice)
- 2 Tbsp vegetable oil or butter

RICE & SEASONING

- 1 ½ cups Carolina Gold rice (or other long-grain rice)
- 2 tsp salt, plus more to taste
- 1 tsp black pepper
- ½ tsp smoked paprika
- ¼ tsp cayenne pepper (optional, for heat)
- Fresh sliced green onions or parsley, for garnish (optional)
- Hot sauce on the side (like Texas Pete or Crystal)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Make the shrimp stock*: Peel the shrimp, saving every shell. Refrigerate the peeled shrimp until you need them. Put the shells in a saucepan with the chicken stock and bay leaf, bring to a gentle simmer, and cook for 15 minutes. Strain, discard the shells and bay leaf, and set the stock aside. You should have about 3 cups; add a splash of water if you're short. Simmering the shells is a small step that draws out a deep, sweet seafood flavor no plain stock can match.
2. *Render the pork*: In a heavy Dutch oven or deep skillet with a lid, cook the diced smoked pork over medium heat until it browns and renders its fat, about 5 minutes. If the pork is lean and the pan looks dry, add the vegetable oil. This rendered, smoky fat is the foundation the whole dish is built on.
3. *Cook the vegetables*: Add the onion and bell pepper to the pot and cook, stirring often, until softened, 6–8 minutes. Stir in the garlic and cook until fragrant, about 1 minute more.

4. *Bloom the tomato paste*: Push the vegetables to the side and add the tomato paste to the open spot in the pan. Let it cook undisturbed for a minute, then stir it into the vegetables and keep cooking until it darkens to a deep brick red, 2–3 minutes. Cooking the paste down like this is the secret to real red rice color and a sweet, concentrated tomato flavor. Stir in the diced tomatoes with their juice and scrape up any browned bits from the bottom.
5. *Add the rice*: Pour in the rice and stir until every grain is coated in the red base. Add the reserved shrimp stock, salt, black pepper, smoked paprika, and cayenne, and stir once to combine. Bring to a boil.
6. *Simmer low and slow*: Reduce the heat to low, cover, and cook without stirring until the rice is tender and the liquid is absorbed, 20–25 minutes. Resist the urge to lift the lid—the steam trapped inside is what cooks the rice evenly. If your pot runs hot, check it near the end so the bottom doesn't scorch.
7. *Fold in the shrimp*: Scatter the peeled shrimp over the top of the rice, cover again, and cook until they turn pink and just firm, 5–7 minutes. Remove from the heat and let it rest, still covered, for 5 minutes. Fluff gently with a fork, folding the shrimp through.
8. *Serve*: Taste and adjust the salt. Serve warm, scattered with green onions or parsley, with hot sauce at the table for those who want it.



